

December 23, 2025

Dominic DeLuca				
Penn State				
Mike Linebacker				
Height: 6010	Weight: 227	Year: 5SR	Jersey #: 0	Hometown: West Pittston, PA
Games Reviewed: 2025 Iowa, Ohio State, Indiana, Rutgers				
2025 Stats:				
Career Stats:				
Scouting Report by: Danny Nolan				

Critical Factors					
3-Down Ability		FBI/Instincts		Play Speed	
5		4		5	
Positional Factors					
3-Level Impact	QB Defense	Stoutness	Shed Ability	Navigate Trash	Tackling
4	6	4	4	5	5
Man Coverage	Zone Coverage	Range	Blitz	Toughness	ST Value
6	5	5	5	5	6

Strengths

- Eliminating checkdown options
- Filling gaps quickly at the line of scrimmage
- Communicating in zone defense

Weaknesses

- Shedding blockers
- Staying disciplined on play fakes
- Playing stout in run game

Overall

Dominic DeLuca is a senior Mike linebacker for the Penn State Nittany Lions. He has spent five years in Happy Valley, redshirting in 2021 before becoming a consistent contributor the following season. He was named a team captain for both of the last two years, and he became a full time starter in 2025. DeLuca is a solid athlete in the middle of any defense, one who won't showcase jaw-dropping agility but will seldom look out of place on the gridiron. His motor and toughness are adequate yet nothing to write home about. He is on the smaller side for a Mike linebacker, and his play strength can be exposed as a glaring weakness.

Pass Game

Through the air, DeLuca is capable in both man and zone coverage. In man defense, he excels at preventing checkdowns, giving tight ends and running backs very little breathing room on short routes. Even on deeper routes, DeLuca can be trusted to keep pace with those pass catchers. However, defensive coordinators shouldn't feel comfortable matching DeLuca with a wide receiver. He lacks the quickness and speed to be anything more than an emergency option against wideouts. This concern is why DeLuca projects to be a Mike linebacker at the next level instead of a Will. In zone coverage, DeLuca demonstrates why he's earned his status as captain. He makes a concerted effort to communicate and ensure his teammates are playing in sync. DeLuca himself is an average zone defender, looking comfortable most of the time but lacking the instincts to excel. Despite plus ball skills, his closing speed and routes to the ball don't impress, and a good fake can pull him out of his zone. As a blitz, DeLuca needs to be untouched or opposing a running back to penetrate the pocket. He doesn't possess the strength or pass rush repertoire to beat a tight end or lineman.

Run Game

On the ground, DeLuca's slighter build impacts his effectiveness. He can be sealed off easily by linemen and tight ends at the second level, and he can struggle to shed those blocks. At the line of scrimmage, DeLuca typically cannot force anything more than a stalemate, despite ample willingness to attack. He does well to fill open running lanes and get downhill quickly, usually making the tackle on the ball carrier when head-on. In those instances, he tackles with impeccable form and strength, sometimes stopping the rusher immediately after contact. However, his tackling can be inconsistent in the open field, as he goes for the rusher's legs and sometimes allows him to escape his grasp. He is fooled by play fakes too often, which renders him a nonfactor on those plays and calls his instincts into question.

Last Word

Since he might have trouble being asked to neutralize slot receivers, DeLuca projects best as a Mike linebacker in the NFL. Fulfilling a Will role in a pinch should be well within DeLuca's capabilities, especially because his size is more typical of a Will linebacker than a Mike. On 3rd down, DeLuca would be most valuable in the Mike role, either in a short zone or matched up against a tight end or running back. DeLuca might not have the physical tools that make special teams coaches salivate, but he certainly has the experience. He won the

John Bruno Memorial Award as Penn State's most outstanding special teamer in 2023, so there's no question he can contribute in that role as a pro.

One-Liner: DeLuca, a bit of a tweener as a linebacker, needs to improve and rely upon his instincts and coverage ability to compensate for his uninspiring physical attributes.

Grade: 5.7 - Ceiling: 5.9 (15%) Floor: 5.4 (15%) Round: UDFA